

Identifying Online Child Sexual Exploitation

Recognising the signs, and how manipulation keeps them hidden



There Is No Single Sign

Online child sexual exploitation can be hard to detect — no single sign proves it has happened. Those who target children rely on manipulation: making a child feel special, encouraging secrecy, or building shame so the child believes they'll be blamed or get in trouble for what's happened. Watching for a pattern of change, not one isolated behaviour, is what matters most.



Relationships & Communication

- Unexplained relationships with older people
- A change in the words or language the child uses
- Sexual behaviours not in line with their age or stage of development



Digital & Daily Life

- Changes in online habits — more or less time online, only being online in private
- Truancy or a drop in school performance
- Staying out late, or not returning home



Gifts, Money & Appearance

- Unexplained gifts, expensive clothes, or mobile phones
- Unexplained money, or frequently needing money for activities
- A change in appearance, or borrowing clothes from others



Wellbeing & Behaviour

- Changes in mood, behaviour, or eating habits
- Always tired
- Regularly using drugs or drinking alcohol



If You Notice These Signs

- Stay calm, and approach your child gently, without judgement
- Let them know you are there to listen, not to punish
- Reassure them — whatever has happened, it is not their fault



Get Support — Sri Lanka

- NCPA Child Helpline — call 1929 (free, 24 hours, in Sinhala, Tamil & English)
- Report images/videos online — NCPA Cyber Crime Division / IWF Sri Lanka Portal at childprotection.gov.lk
- Police Emergency — call 119
- Email NCPA — complaints@childprotection.gov.lk



If your child is a victim, it is important they know: it is not their fault.

Notice several of these signs together? Start a gentle, judgement-free conversation and reach out for support.

NCPA Child Helpline: 1929 | Police Emergency: 119 | **IFDC Training & Resources** — www.ifdchild.org